

Author's Preface (自序)

Like many Chinese of my generation, I spent my childhood and youth within a relatively oppressive "Chinese-style" family environment and educational system. Because the atmosphere around me strongly disapproved of "useless entertainment," and reading extracurricular books was one of the few methods of relaxation unlikely to attract criticism, I developed a deep reliance on reading during that time. During my formative years, I discovered that I was not a particularly extroverted person who loved making a wide circle of friends; rather, I was content with establishing profound bonds with a few individuals, and I felt genuine joy in helping others. During middle school, I would participate in community volunteer activities whenever I had free time, which was when I began to develop a concern for social realities.

During my undergraduate studies, my personal observations and reading led to growing doubts regarding the condition of Chinese society. I realized that there might be some more enduring, endogenous factors (内生性因素) influencing—or even determining—the course of China's history. This judgment prompted me to read a massive amount of literature on Chinese history in my spare time. For if such factors truly existed, it would be highly unlikely for me to glimpse the whole picture merely through a short-term historical process—such as one or two generations, or even a century or two. But how far back should I trace? I also felt that social science, unlike natural science or the mathematics I was studying, made it difficult to find an absolute, universally recognized, and standard "process of human history." Therefore, if I wanted to understand the rhythm of Chinese history, I had no choice but to look at the histories of many other countries and regions as mirrors. If I could find the point of divergence between China's historical trajectory and that of other parts of the world—especially Western civilization—then there would be an opportunity to find clues within Chinese history from that divergence up to the present. Fortunately, I found that many domestic and international scholars had already focused on this issue and made considerable progress, which made me even more convinced that obtaining an answer was not a mere fantasy.

Under the influence of three major events, I achieved some breakthroughs around the National Day of 2022. Subsequently, utilizing domestic and foreign materials, I confirmed that the direction of my thinking was fundamentally correct. These three events were: the draconian pandemic

prevention policies (严苛防疫政策) that were arousing increasing public resentment in mainland China; Russia's foolish invasion of Ukraine and its botched performance; and the dramatic shifts in mainland public opinion surrounding the U.S. House Speaker's visit to Taiwan in August 2022. Simultaneously, I personally felt the sharp deterioration of the environment in my own life: people's expectations for the economy turned extremely poor, and the birth rate data mercilessly laid the problems bare. These facts I observed prompted me to respond based on a certain human instinct: I needed an explanation for the changes. Why was the world evolving in the direction I was seeing?

By the end of that year, I had arrived at a new interpretation of Chinese history—or more accurately, a new periodization—one that can explain its continuous evolution from antiquity all the way down to the establishment and operational logic of the current Chinese regime. I realized that many of the major historical questions debated by the Chinese historical community were now coherently encapsulated by this new interpretation. However, at that time, I was busy with my

graduation and securing my spot for graduate school. More importantly, I was still questioning whether the methods and conclusions I adopted in researching Chinese history possessed

universality (普世性). Did the developmental processes of other civilized societies experience the same stages and tendencies? If so, what exact variables ultimately caused them to diverge? I could not answer these questions at the time, so I did not record them.

Since then, in my spare time alongside my coursework, I have been continuously trying to resolve these remaining questions. By the autumn of last year (2024), I arrived at an affirmative answer. Although it sounds truly unbelievable, can the history of human civilization really be explained by unified sociological laws? Perhaps there will not be a definitive answer for several more generations, but I am convinced that I have taken a massive step forward. Although my work initially merely sought to answer a question I desperately wanted resolved for myself, I still decided to record my journey and discoveries, resulting in a manuscript of over 400,000 words.

Completing so many discoveries and drafting this manuscript was exceedingly arduous. Even disregarding the colossal scale and profound implications of the issues I was investigating, merely overcoming the difficulties imposed by my environment was no easy task. Readers will naturally understand that living in the place where I reside means not only that certain materials are less accessible, but also that one inevitably carries some deeply ingrained habits when observing issues. Over the course of several years, I have constantly struggled against the "conditioned viewpoints" (既定视角) I possessed, striving to ensure that their limitations did not compromise the credibility of the arguments themselves.

Of course, relying solely on the guarantee of rationalism, balancing a sensitivity to human moral conscience, and expanding the scope of information search are not enough. Ultimately, whether any scientific theory is correct requires it to withstand testing. People often say that falsifiability (可证伪性) should be a vital characteristic of science. Can social science achieve falsifiability? It is currently unknown. As a student of mathematics, I think that no matter how hard social science tries, it cannot unfold through formal logic and axiomatic systems (形式逻辑和公理化体系) like mathematics. But people should at least strive to bring its rigor closer to the natural sciences. Therefore, I extensively examined the affairs of the world in all directions, from ancient times to the present—paying particular attention to learning the academic consensus on certain historical questions and acknowledging them when the evidence was sufficient—to subject every one of my arguments to the most neutral testing possible.

Now, I can say with great certainty that my newly discovered theory is reliable. Because I realized that I have overturned almost none of the accepted consensus; rather, I have pieced the already-acquired puzzle pieces into a unified picture. If the overall history of humanity were an elephant, then according to the Chinese idiom of "blind men touching an elephant" (盲人摸象), previous scholars have practically touched every part of the elephant. They provided highly precise descriptions of the parts they examined. The problem lies in the fact that these pioneers had no way of realizing that they were, in fact, touching the *same* "elephant." What I did was merely to touch again the parts people had already touched, and make necessary corrections to some erroneous records. For example, when earlier scholars touched the elephant's ear and wrote down, "This is a

fan," I would correct it to, "This is an ear." But, of course, our views on the shape and size of the elephant's ear are identical; just as I would not "invent" new historical facts. The sole issue is that past scholars were highly likely unable to provide accurate qualitative characterizations for solid historical facts, resulting in 'functional misinterpretations.' I discovered that we only need to modify the few most critical characterizations and restore them to their correct positions within the historical structure; then, the puzzle almost naturally pieces itself together. That I was able to discover these few most critical errors is entirely thanks to the peculiarity of Chinese history within human history, and to the fact that the abysmal explanatory power of official historiography planted the seeds of doubt in people's minds.

1, 自序

我和同一辈的很多中国人一样，都在一个相对压抑的“中国式”家庭环境和教育体制内度过了少年和青年时光。因为我所处的氛围很不赞同“无用的娱乐”，而阅读课外书籍是少有的不易遭到非议的放松办法，所以在那个时候我养成了对阅读的依赖。在我性格的形成期，我发现自己并不是一个特别外向，喜好广交朋友的人，我满足于与少数人建立深厚的情谊，也对帮助他人感到由衷的快乐。中学的时候我一得空就会去参加社区公益活动，这时我对于社会现实产生了关切。

在读本科期间，我个人的见闻和阅读使我对于中国社会的境况产生了越来越多的疑惑。我意识到或许存在某种更为持久的、内生性的因素左右甚至决定了中国的历史进程。如上判断使得我在业余时间阅读了大量有关中国历史的文献，因为如果这种因素真的存在的话，那么我不太可能仅仅通过短期的历史进程，比如一代人、两代人，甚至一百年、二百年窥见全貌。可是应当上溯到什么时候呢，我又感到社会科学毕竟不同于自然科学或者我所学的数学，很难找到一个绝对的、公认的、标准的“人类历史进程”。因此我如果想要了解中国历史的律动，就不得不把很多国家和地区的历史作为镜子来看。如果能找到中国历史进程与世界其他地区，尤其是与西方文明的分歧点，那么就有机会从分歧开始至今的中国历史中找到端倪。幸运的是，我发现已经有不少国内外学者关注并在解决这一问题上取得了诸多进展，这也令我更加相信得到答案并非是天方夜谭。

在三个重要事件的影响下，我在 2022 年的国庆节取得了一些突破，随即我从国内外的资料确认了自己思考的方向基本正确。这三件事分别是：在中国大陆引起民众愈发不满的严苛防疫政策；俄国对乌克兰愚蠢的入侵及其拙劣表现；2022 年 8 月 2 日美国众议院议长访问台湾前后大陆舆论的戏剧性变化。与此同时，我个人也在生活中感受到了环境的急转直下，人

们对于经济的预期变得很差，出生人口数据更是毫不留情地把问题摆到台面上。这些我观察到的事实促使我根据人类的某种本能做出应答：我需要得到变化的解释，为什么世界正在向我看到的方向演变？

在当年年底，我获得了一种对于中国历史的新解释，或者更准确的说是一种新的分期，它从古代开始一直可以解释到中国现政权的成立和运行逻辑。我意识到，中国历史学界关于我国历史的许多重大问题，现在都被一致地纳入了新的解释框架之中。但是当时我正忙于保研和毕业，更重要的是，我还在怀疑自己对于中国历史的研究过程中所采取的一些方法和结论是否具有普世性，在其他文明社会的发展进程里，也有过相同的阶段和倾向吗？如果有的话，究竟 是哪些变量使得它们最终走向了不同？当时我并不能回答，因此没有把它记录下来。

从那时起，我在课业之余一直在尝试解决遗留问题。到去年（2024 年）秋天，我得到了肯定的回答。虽然听起来实在是令人难以置信，人类文明的历史真的能被统一的社会学规律解释吗？或许将来再过几代人也不会有准确的回答，但我确信我已经向前迈出一大步。我的工作最初只是想要回答一个我自己渴望答案的问题，但我还是决定把我的经历和发现记录下来，形成了一份多达四十余万字的文稿。

完成这么多的发现并撰写文稿非常艰难，即使不考虑我考察问题规模之宏大，影响之深刻，仅仅是克服我所处的环境带来的难题就已经不容易了。读者自然明白，生活在我所处的地方不仅仅意味着一些资料没那么容易找到，而且在看问题的时候也必然会有一些长期以来养成的习惯。在几年间，我一直在和自己拥有的“既定视角”做斗争，力图使其局限性不影响观点本身的可信。

当然，仅仅由理性主义做保障，兼顾对人类道德良知的感受，扩大信息搜索的范围也是不够的。归根到底，任何科学理论是否正确，都要求它经得住检验。人们经常说，可证伪性应当是科学的一个重要特征。社会科学能够做到可证伪吗？现在并不知道。作为数学专业的学生，我想社会科学即使再怎么努力也无法像数学一样凭借形式逻辑和公理化体系展开。但是人们至少应该努力让其严谨性上能够向自然科学靠拢。所以我广泛考察天下四方，古往今来之事，特别是注意学习学界在一些史学问题上的公论，并且在证据充分的情况下承认他们，对于我的每一个观点进行尽可能中立的检验。

现在，我可以很肯定的说，我新发现的理论是可靠的。因为我意识到我几乎没有推翻任何公论，而是把已经取得的拼图拼成了一幅统一的图景。如果说人类总体的历史是一头大象的话，按照中国“盲人摸象”的典故，先前的学者们已经几乎摸遍了大象的各个部位，他们对于自己所考察大象的部位做出了相当精确的描述。问题在于，这些先驱们没有办法意识到彼此摸的实际上是同一头“大象”。而我做的只是重新把人们已经摸到的部分再摸一遍，对于一些错误的记录进行必要的修正，比如说原先的学者在摸到大象耳朵的时候，写下“这是一面扇子”，我会把它改成“这是一只耳朵”。但是当然，我们对于大象耳朵形状，大小的看法是一样的，这就如同我不会“发明”新的史实一样。唯一的问题在于，过去的学者很可能对于确凿的史实无法进行准确的定性，做出了“功能性的误读”。而我发现，我们只需要对最关键的几处定性进行修改，还原它们在历史结构中的正确位置，那么拼图几乎自然就被拼起来了。我之所以能够发现最关键的几处错误，这还多亏了中国历史在人类历史中的特殊性，以及官方史学那糟糕的解释能力在人心中埋下了怀疑的种子。

Introduction (导言)

For a long time, both the mainstream Western Sinological community, including that of the United States, and the Japanese community of Oriental history, when discussing the "point of divergence" between the historical processes of China and the West, have generally tended to locate it within the last millennium. Among them, theories positing an earlier timeframe (such as the "Tang-Song Transition" theory / 唐宋变革论) believe the decisive change occurred between the Tang and Song dynasties; while theories positing a later timeframe argue that this Great Divergence did not truly become prominent until the Ming and Qing dynasties or even the *early modern period*.

Based on the perspective and methodology of comparative historical sociology, I argue that the point of divergence between the historical processes of China and other parts of the world should be traced back much earlier. It ought to be located in China between the 3rd and 6th centuries CE during the Wei, Jin, and Northern and Southern Dynasties (魏晋南北朝)—a stage referred to by Western scholars as "**Early Medieval China**." The reason is that, although China experienced a massive migration of peoples similar to that in Western Europe, its process of *feudalization* (封建化) suffered an interruption and regression, leading to the abnormal restoration of the bureaucratic system in the 7th century.

To understand the causes behind this phenomenon, I believe we must trace back at least to the mid-Warring States period of China, with a particular focus on the profound political changes that occurred during the mid-Western Han Dynasty—the period of the most intense warfare between the Han Empire and the Xiongnu (匈奴). Simultaneously, this observation must be extended forward to the Northern and Southern Song dynasties. During those three hundred years, although the *landlord class* (地主阶级) in China had been completely suppressed by the *bureaucratic state*, intellectuals still possessed a relatively clear concept of a "*feudal era*" (*feudal period* / 封建时代). If we cannot understand—under the premise that the *feudal economic system* (封建经济制度) inevitably became the historical mainstream—exactly what methods the Chinese bureaucratic system employed to strangle the *feudal political system* (封建政治制度), rendering the Chinese *landlord class* unable to transform into "*feudal lords*" like their counterparts in Western Europe and Japan, then we will never be able to provide a logically consistent explanation for the stagnation and distortion of Chinese society over the millennium from the Sui and Tang down to the Ming and Qing dynasties.

In **Chapters 1 and 2**, I first point out the fact that China's *classical bureaucratic system* (古典官僚体制) was not destroyed during the worldwide collapse of *classical empires* (caused by *feudalization* and the influx of borderland peoples), and that the *bureaucratic state* was rebuilt around 600 CE. The ethnic minorities that entered *the Central Plains* (中原) relatively rarely deprived the Han people—especially Han landlords—of their land property rights; that is, they did

not choose **feudalization** but instead turned to bureaucratization. This phenomenon of compromise was a crucial external factor in the survival of the bureaucratic system. I focused on examining the historical documents from the phase of confrontation between the Eastern Wei, Northern Qi,

Western Wei, and Northern Zhou (东魏、北齐和西魏、北周), finding compelling evidence of distinct **feudalization** characteristics emerging in northern China during this period. As for the internal factor—namely, the issue that China's pre-existing bureaucratic system was already too entrenched before the massive inward migration of ethnic minorities—I trace its origin back to the mid-Western Han Dynasty in Chapter 2, with supplementary explanations provided in subsequent sections of the manuscript.

In **Chapter 3**, based on the research achievements Western scholars have made regarding **early modern society** (近代社会) and **absolutist states** (绝对主义国家), I argue that the “**classical period**” (**classical era** / 古典时期) ought to possess distinct transitional characteristics, much like the **early modern period**. This explains the phenomenon of the universal rise of **classical empires** (古典帝国) in Rome, Iran, India, and China in the centuries around the turn of the common era. Furthermore, through comparison with general **classical states**, one can see much more clearly the unique changes that occurred in China during the mid-Western Han Dynasty.

In **Chapter 4**, utilizing the research achievements of Japanese scholars, I use Japan and China as a control group. Japan introduced a bureaucratic system from China in the 7th and 8th centuries CE, yet ultimately still evolved into a **feudal society** similar to **medieval** Western Europe. By comparing Japan with China, we can not only more clearly understand how the Chinese bureaucratic system shaped Chinese history since the Tang Dynasty, but also understand why Japan was able to become a uniquely developed nation in Asia. **Chapter 5** briefly discusses the two regimes of Nanzhao (南诏) and Dali (大理) in the Yunnan region, realigning the history of the southwestern region, which has been inverted in our national historical narrative.

In **Chapter 6**, through theoretical deduction, I explain why China could not embark on the path to modernization on its own like Western Europe, and why it evolved into a so-called communist state in the last century. The most extraordinary innovation of this chapter is that I break through the limitations of Marx and Engels, who only traced their political economy and class view of history back to humans. Instead, I trace the roots of historical materialism back to the material world itself—namely, which *factor of production* occupies the core position in labor production. In doing so, I avoid the dilemma of having to resort to moral criticism, sweeping away the previous “idealistic materialism” (唯心的唯物主义). It is precisely the pioneering achievement of this chapter that enables me to provide relatively precise definitions for those vague and erroneous concepts previously utilized by people. In **Chapter 7**, I refute two popular theories: that the maintenance of the Chinese bureaucratic system was necessitated by the military pressure of northern nomadic peoples, and by the need for water conservancy construction.

Chapters 8 and 9, through my personal reflections on certain practical and cognitive issues existing in Chinese society, illustrate the impact of the interruption of **feudalization** and the restoration of the bureaucratic system on contemporary China. **Chapter 10** is a brief essay focusing on the seasonal cycles of political tension. **Chapter 11**, by reviewing vital fragments from the

histories of the Islamic world and the Byzantine Empire, reveals a series of major impacts caused by the process of *feudalization* in *the Near East region* (近东地区). In particular, by using Byzantium—a *classical state* that at first glance appears similar to China but is fundamentally different, and which survived the wave of *feudalization*—as a comparison, I emphasize the peculiarity of China's *restoration-bureaucratic system* (复辟官僚制度).

Chapter 12 re-narrates human history using my adjusted periodization theory, placing the focus on the period from the formative stage of the *classical era* to the *Late Middle Ages* (中世纪晚期). In this chapter, I further perfect the theory of the formation mechanism of *classical empires*, completely explain the reasons for the "divergence" (分流) between China and the West, and smoothly apply the British sociologist Michael Mann's distinction between *infrastructural power* (基础性权力) and *despotic power* (专制性权力) to my investigation. I explore the differences in historical developmental processes between China and other major regions of the world, and, using the history of the spread of Buddhism as an example, re-describe the changes in social thought during the process of *feudalization*. I review the economic differences between China and the West in the pre-industrial period—an issue scholars have always focused on—and point out that this difference should be attributed to the restoration of the bureaucratic system, which in turn consolidated the restored bureaucratic system. Regarding modern and contemporary Chinese issues of concern to domestic and foreign observers, I also provide new answers based on the course of Chinese history. In Section 30 of Chapter 12, I provide explanations for the terminology used throughout this record that might invite questioning.

Chapter 13 contains my insights and reflections, reaffirming the existence of unified scientific laws in the development of human history, denying the possibility of a direct transition from the *classical period* to the *early modern period*, and pointing out the potential obstructive role of technological progress on mutual understanding between nations.

When I first set pen to paper to write such a record, my initial intention was merely to use the countries of the world as mirrors to reflect China's past and reality. However, as I neared completion, I discovered: for other countries in the world, is China not also a mirror in which they can clearly see themselves? The successes, failures, advantages, and blunts in Chinese history reveal the origins of "*modernity*" (现代性) to people from an absolutely unique angle.

After reading the main text of the manuscript, readers might naturally develop the following question: the *primary factor of production* (首位生产要素) and the *historical sequence* (历史序列) delineated by it undoubtedly occupy the core of the manuscript's theory, yet the frequency of the *primary factor of production* appearing in the text is actually not high. In reality, it is exceedingly difficult for people to quantitatively determine which factor of production occupied the primary position in a specific society during a specific historical period. In practice, when determining the *primary factor of production*, we still rely on observations of social structures and social phenomena. This also makes it impossible for me to let the *primary factor of production* directly

participate in explaining too many historical issues, because doing so would easily trap me in circular reasoning [循环论证], which I find utterly unacceptable.

As the author, my response to this question is this: **The true value of this manuscript lies not merely in proposing a few new historical explanations, but in forming a new hierarchical level for observing the historical evolution of human society.**

My friends, please consider this: Has the field of social sciences in the past truly lacked insightful theories? Absolutely not. Some theories emphasize **class** (阶级) relations, some emphasize economics, some emphasize geopolitics, and some emphasize culture and religion—examples are **too numerous to list** (不胜枚举). A wise person would not deny the success achieved by these existing theories; they have indeed explained portions of historical truths. However, these theories frequently sink into protracted debates precisely because they mutually attempt to become the *sole* explanation, to the extent that academic research degenerates into factional politics. The reason why generations of debate have failed to allow any single theory to ultimately **unify the realm** (一统天下) is likely because, although these theories all possess merit, the vast majority of them remain situated on the exact same analytical level.

Therefore, this manuscript does not attempt to replace existing theories with a new one; rather, it attempts to elevate the hierarchical level of historical observation further upward. The proposition of the **primary factor of production** is not intended to directly explain all historical phenomena, but to elevate the dimension of observation, redefining the applicable scopes for different theories. To borrow the language of mathematics, every single theory is not an independent variable [自变量] capable of determining all answers. If the **primary factor of production** is the paramount independent variable, then some theories study the initial conditions, some study the parameters, some study the intervening variables [中间变量], some study boundary effects, some study regular perturbations, and some study random perturbations. The relationship among different theories is no longer one of mutual competition and mutual exclusion; instead, within a unified framework, they separately explain historical issues at different levels, collectively constituting the "evolutionary equation of human society" [人类社会的演化方程]. **I believe that a good theory does not demand that the world submit to it, but rather helps the world better understand itself.**

Therefore, the **primary factor of production** essentially plays the role of a figurehead monarch; as a overarching analytical principle, it **reigns but does not rule** (统而不治). It is not like a despotic monarch [专制君主] who must be **attending to myriad daily affairs and making dictatorial decisions** (日理万机、乾纲独断), existing as an exhaustive, all-encompassing explanatory tool. The **primary factor of production** will not replace economic, class, cultural, military, or geopolitical analyses. Instead, exactly like a constitutional monarch [立宪君主], it grants various theories their respective legitimate positions, providing a shared historical coordinate system for these analyses so that they can be **secure in their proper places** (各安其位) and cooperate harmoniously, no longer

overstepping their bounds. What the attempts of this manuscript truly seek to alter is not any single historical conclusion, but rather the very methodology by which historical facts are observed and organized—yet it is solidly built upon the foundation of public consensus already established within the academic community.

Throughout the process of writing this manuscript, I have constantly harbored the following conviction: **Any theory must accept questioning; any explanation must face evidence; any conclusion must allow itself to be overturned.** I hope this manuscript can provide convenience for humanity's future exploration of itself. Anyone is welcome to criticize, revise, expand upon, or refute any viewpoint within it. If superior evidence and reasoning emerge in the future, the pursuit of truth should perpetually transcend loyalty to the manuscript itself. If this manuscript can bring any tangible change to the world, I believe it lies in this: regardless of its degree of success or failure, it will ultimately reduce the costs and prices exacted by "cognitive fallacies" within the social sciences.

The manuscript was initially completed in mid-March 2025. The following year may one day be engraved in human history as the "Year One of AI." Feeling the astonishing impact of AI increasingly in my life and studies, this revolution inspired me, leading me to complete the manuscript's postscript (**Chapter 14**) in the spring of 2026, wherein I explored what kind of shock the rise of artificial intelligence will bring to China's *restoration-bureaucratic system*. In May, approaching my graduation with a master's degree, I also wrote a short essay titled "Thoughts on the Future" (展望未来), attempting to make limited predictions about the future of humanity based on the discovered theories. This short essay is not included in the manuscript.

2, 导言

长期以来，无论是包括美国在内的西方主流汉学界，还是日本的东洋史学界，在探讨“中国与西方历史进程的分歧点”时，总体上倾向于将其定位在最近的一千年内。其中，判定较早的理论（如“唐宋变革论”）认为决定性变化发生在唐宋之际；而判定较晚的理论则认为这种大分流直到明清甚至近代才真正凸显。基于比较历史学的视角和方法，我认为中国与世界各地历史进程的分歧点要早很多，应当将其定位在三世纪到六世纪之间魏晋南北朝时期的中国，也就是西方学者所称的“早期中世纪中国”的阶段。原因在于，中国虽然经历了与欧洲西部相似的民族大迁徙事件，但是封建化过程发生了中断和倒退，导致官僚体制在七世纪异常地复辟。为了了解这种现象发生的原因，我认为至少应该前溯到中国战国时代中期，也并且着重观察西汉中叶汉帝国与匈奴战争最激烈时期中国在政治上发生的重大变化。同时向后延伸到两宋时期，在那三百年间中国的地主阶级虽已完全被官僚国家所压制，但知识分子依然具有比较清楚的对于“封建时代”的概念。如果我们不能理解，在封建经济制度不可避免地成为历史主流的前提下，中国的官僚体制究竟采取了何种手段去扼杀封建政治制度，使得中国的地主阶级无法像西欧和日本的同行那样转化为“封建领主”；我们就永

远无法对隋唐以降直至明清这一千多年间中国社会的停滞与畸变，给出一个逻辑自洽的解释。

在第一章和第二章中，我首先指出了中国的古典官僚制度在世界范围内普遍的因为封建化和边疆民族迁入引起的古典帝国崩溃中没有被摧毁，官僚国家在公元 600 年前后重建的事实。进入中原的少数民族相对而言极少剥夺汉族特别是汉族地主的土地产权，即没有选择封建化转而官僚化，这种妥协现象是官僚制度得以幸存的重要外部因素。我着重考察了东魏、北齐和西魏、北周对峙阶段的历史文献，找到了这一时期中国北方出现明显封建化特征的有力证据。而内部因素也就是少数民族大规模内迁前中国原有的官僚体制本身就过于稳固这一问题，我在第二章中先将其缘起确定在西汉中叶，在接下来的文稿中有补充的解释。

在第三章中，我基于西方学者已取得的对于近代社会和绝对主义国家的研究成果，认为“古典时期”应当与近代一样具有明显的过渡特征。这样就解释了罗马、伊朗、印度和中国在公元前后的几个世纪内古典帝国普遍崛起的现象，并且通过与一般古典国家的对比，人们可以更加清楚地看到西汉中叶中国所发生的特殊变化。

在第四章中，我基于日本学者的研究成果将日本与中国作为一个对照组。日本于公元七、八世纪从中国引入了一套官僚制度，但是仍然最终演变成为了与中世纪西欧相似的封建社会。通过将日本与中国比较，我们既可以更清楚地认识唐代以来中国官僚制度如何塑造中国历史，也能够了解日本为什么能够成为在亚洲独树一帜的发达国家。第五章简要讨论了云南地区南诏和大理两个政权，并重新捋顺了在我国叙事中被颠倒的西南地区历史。

在第六章中，我通过理论推导解释了中国为什么无法像西部欧洲一样自行走上现代化道路，以及为什么在上个世纪演变成为所谓的共产主义国家。这一章最为非凡的创新是，我突破了马克思和恩格斯当年仅仅把其政治经济学和阶级史观上溯到人的局限，将历史唯物主义的根源上溯到物质世界本身，也即哪一种生产要素处于劳动生产中的核心位置。如此，我就可以避免必须诉诸道德批判的困境，将此前“唯心的唯物主义”一扫而空。也正是这一章的创举，使得我能够对于人们之前所运用的那些模糊、错误的概念进行相对精确的定义。在第七章中，我反驳了两个流行的理论，即中国官僚制度的维持是面对北方游牧民族的军事压力和水利建设的需要。

第八章和第九章通过我个人对中国社会在现实中和认识上存在的一些问题的反思，说明了封建化中断和官僚制度复辟对于当代中国的影响。第十章是一篇简短的随笔，关注了政治紧张的季节性周期。第十一章通过回顾伊斯兰世界和拜占庭帝国历史中的重要片段，揭示了封建化进程在近东地区造成的一系列重大影响。特别是通过拜占庭这样一个乍看起来与中国相似，但是实质不同的在封建化浪潮中幸存的古典国家作为比照，我强调了中国复辟官僚制度的特殊性。

第十二章用经过我调整的历史分期理论对人类历史进行了重新叙述，把重点放到了古典时代的形成期至中世纪晚期。这一章中我进一步完善了古典帝国的形成机制理论，完全解释了中国与西方相“分流”的原因，将英国社会学家迈克尔曼对于基础性权力和专制性权力的区分顺利地应用在考察中。我探讨了世界各主要地区与中国历史发展进程的差异，并以佛教传播史为例再次描述了封建化进程中社会思想的变化。我回顾了学者们一直以来关注的有关中西方在前工业时期经济上所存在的差异，并且指出这种差异应当归因于官僚制度的复辟，并且反过来又巩固了复辟官僚制度。对于中外观察者比较关心的中国近现代问题，我也基于中国历史进程给出了新的回答。在第十二章的第三十节，我对整份记录中所用到的可能引起疑问的名词做出了解释。

第十三章是我的心得和反思，再次肯定了人类历史发展中统一科学规律的存在，否定了从古典时期直接过渡到近代的可能性，并且指出技术进步对于各国之间互相了解的潜在阻碍作用。

我在落笔写这样一份记录的时候，最初不过是想以世界各国为镜子照出中国的过往和现实。但是当我快要写完的时候，我发现对于世界上其他国家而言，中国何尝是不是一面能够照清自己的镜子。中国历史上的成败利钝恰恰从一个独一无二的角度向人们展现了“现代性”的由来。

读者在读完文稿的正文之后，或许会产生这样一个自然而然的疑问：首位生产要素和通过其划分的历史序列无疑占据了文稿理论的核心，但首位生产要素在文稿中出现的频率并不高。实际上，人们很难定量地去判断某个社会在特定历史时期中哪个生产要素处于首要位置。在实践中去确定首位生产要素时，我们仍然会依赖于对于社会结构及社会现象的观察。

这也使得我不可能让首位生产要素直接参与太多对于历史问题的解释，因为如此一来则很容易陷入我不可能接受的循环论证。

作为作者，我对这一疑问的回应是，本文真正的价值并非仅仅是提出一些新的历史解释，而是形成了一套观察人类社会历史演化的新层级。

朋友们，请想一想，难道在过去社会科学领域真的缺少富有洞见的理论吗？事实绝非如此，有的理论强调阶级关系，有的理论强调经济，有的理论强调地缘，有的理论强调文化和宗教，诸如此类，不胜枚举。一个明智的人不会否认这些已有的理论取得的成功，他们的确都解释了历史中的一部分事实。然而，这些理论又常常因为彼此试图成为唯一的解释，而陷入长期的争论，以至于让学术研究演变成为派阀政治。之所以几代人的争论也没有办法使哪个理论最终“一统天下”，原因恐怕在于这些理论虽然都有可取之处，但他们大多仍处于同一个分析层级。

因此，本文并不试图以一种新的理论去取代已有的理论，而是尝试将观察历史的层级进一步上移。首位生产要素的提出并不是为了直接解释所有历史现象，而是将观察上升的一个维度，为不同理论重新规定各自适用的范围。如果借用数学的语言来说，每一个理论都不是能够决定所有答案的自变量。如果说首位生产要素是最重要的自变量，那么有些理论研究了初始条件，有些理论研究了参数，有些理论研究了中间变量，有些理论研究了边界的影响，有些理论研究了规律性的扰动，有些理论研究了随机的扰动。不同理论之间不再是彼此竞争、相互排斥的关系，而是在统一框架下分别解释不同层面的历史问题，共同构成了“人类社会的演化方程”。我认为好的理论不是要求世界服从它，而是帮助世界更好地理解自己。

所以，首位生产要素本质上扮演了一个虚君的角色，它作为一种统摄性的分析原则“统而不治”，而非像一个专制君主一样必须日理万机、乾纲独断，作为一种事无巨细、包揽一切的解释工具存在。首位生产要素并不会替代经济、阶级、文化、军事、地缘等分析，而是如同立宪君主一样授予各种理论各自的合法位置，为这些分析提供共同的历史坐标，使他们能够各安其位，相互配合，而不再彼此越界。文稿的尝试真正要改变的不是某一个历史结论，而是观察和组织历史事实的方式，但是它坚实地建立在学界已有公论的基础上。

在写文稿的过程中，我始终怀揣着如下的信念：任何理论都必须接受质疑；任何解释都必须面对证据；任何结论都必须允许被推翻。我希望这份文稿能够为未来人类对自身的探索提供方便。任何人都可以批评、修正、扩展或反驳其中任何观点。如果未来出现更好的证据和推理，那么对真理的追求应始终高于对文稿本身的忠诚。如果说这篇文稿能为世界带来什么实际改变的话，我想就在于无论它成败几何，最终都能够降低社会科学中“错误认识”带来的成本和代价。

文稿最初完成于 2025 年 3 月中旬，随后的一年日后或许将以“AI 元年”文明隽刻在人类的历史上。我在生活和学习中也越来越感觉到 AI 产生的惊人影响，这种变革启发了我，使我在 2026 年春天完成了文稿的后记（第十四章），并在其中探讨了人工智能的兴起将会给中国的复辟官僚制度带来怎样的冲击。在临近硕士研究生毕业的 5 月份，我还撰写了一篇名为“展望未来”的短文，试着根据已发现理论对于人类的未来进行有限的预测，这篇短文不被收录在文稿中。